

Civil Rights

The demand for civil and human rights has been a major feature of political and social movements worldwide since the early 20th century. Among the many causes that have been fought for are the right of women to vote and equal rights for ethnic minorities.

Human rights are built on the idea that all people should enjoy minimum standards in many areas of life, including the right to liberty, freedom of expression and conscience, to be treated equally before the law, and not to be tortured or subjected to degrading treatment. In 1948 these ideals were published by the General Assembly of the United Nations in the “Universal Declaration of Human Rights.” Other United Nations Conventions (agreements among member countries) have followed, including the elimination of racial discrimination (1969), outlawing torture (1987), and the rights of the child (1989).

By contrast, civil rights are written into the laws or constitution of a country to protect its citizens. They relate only to citizens in that country. Most democracies, including the United States, Canada, France, and Germany, have civil rights written into their constitutions, although this does not necessarily mean that in practice all people are treated equally. Nor do countries have to be full democracies to proclaim civil rights. In 1936, the Soviet Union proclaimed a new constitution outlining civil rights, but they only existed on paper and were never implemented.

The right to vote

A fundamental civil right is the right to full citizenship, but women and ethnic minorities have often had to fight hard to obtain it. In the early

Hunger strike medal of honor

In July 1909, Majorie Wallace Dunlop became the first suffragette to go on hunger strike. Many others followed her lead. In retaliation, the British government introduced the brutal process of force-feeding. Women who braved the experience wore hunger-strike medals.

Selling The Suffragette

Women had to overcome many barriers to claim their right to vote. In 1912 the Women's Social and Political Union (WSPU) launched its own newspaper, *The Suffragette*. Hundreds of long-skirted women sold the paper in public, challenging social convention and risking public hostility.

Against the vote
Opponents of women's right to vote used any methods to attack the suffragettes. Posters lampooned them as haridans, who should be forcibly shackled and gagged.



“Civil liberties victories never stay won, but must be fought for over and over again.”

IRA GLASSER, EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR OF THE AMERICAN CIVIL LIBERTIES UNION, 1978–2001

20th century, in both Britain and the US, the demand for the vote for women became a major issue.

In Britain the campaign began in 1867 when Parliament proposed to extend suffrage (the right to vote) to a wider range of men but still exclude women. For the next 50 years a



growing tide of protests, demonstrations, and petitions made this one of the most divisive issues in modern British politics. In 1903, the militant Women's Social and Political Union (WSPU) was formed by Emmeline Pankhurst. Frustrated by the failure to achieve the vote by peaceful means, suffragettes, as these women became known, took direct action, including invading the Houses of Parliament. Many were imprisoned. The campaign finally achieved success in 1918 when women age 30 and over obtained the vote. Equal voting rights with men were granted in 1928.

A similar but more peaceful campaign began in the US in the 1840s. The first state to grant women the vote was Wyoming in 1869; nationally, women

won the vote in 1920. In the end, in both countries, women got the vote as a direct acknowledgment of their crucial role in securing victory in World War I. However, voting alone did not confer equal citizenship. Discrimination in other areas continued, and from about 1970 a second women's rights movement fought for and succeeded in changing the law to ensure equality at work and elsewhere. This campaign showed that changes in the law mean little unless economic inequalities are also addressed. Even if they have the vote, women worldwide still experience discrimination, as do other minorities.

African-American and black rights

One of the best-known civil rights campaigns of modern times was waged in the US. During the 1950s and early 1960s, black Americans led by Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. (pp.432–33), fought for the end of segregation—whereby black people were

discriminated against in many areas such as education and transportation—and full civil rights. Years of civil disobedience resulted in a series of important legal changes that ended segregation in many areas and removed literacy tests preventing black Americans from voting.

In South Africa, too, a bitter struggle began against apartheid after 1948. This government-enforced policy of segregation denied black Africans the vote and many other rights (see pp.454–55). When apartheid ended after 1991 and South Africa held its first fully democratic elections in 1994, the sight of thousands of black voters lining up to exercise their new right to vote reaffirmed the importance of a basic civil right many of us now take for granted.

Human rights remain a key issue, with many at risk or being eroded worldwide.

CHALLENGES TO CIVIL LIBERTIES

Civil liberties, such as the right to privacy, may be suspended during wartime. After the 9/11 attacks on New York **466–67** >>

and the start of the “war on terror,” countries such as Britain and the US passed **antiterrorist laws** that allow authorities to intercept electronic data, and to detain suspected terrorists for longer without charge. Some people think these laws **threaten hard-won civil rights**; others think they are justified to prevent terrorism.



SURVEILLANCE CAMERAS

CIVIL RIGHTS AROUND THE WORLD

Since the 1960s, many minority groups have struggled to put an end to discrimination. During the 1990s, Britain and the US introduced **disability acts**.

Gay rights activists have struggled for years to achieve full citizenship. Denmark has recognized **civil unions** since 1989.

Other European countries, such as France, Germany, Portugal, and Britain, slowly followed suit. In 2000, Vermont enacted the first US civil union.



CIVIL PARTNERSHIP CEREMONY

1893 The year that New Zealand became the first country to grant women equal voting rights.

1902 The year that Australia granted equal voting rights to women.



Marching for rights

National Guard troops watch with bayonets raised as African-American sanitation workers march peacefully in Memphis, Tennessee in April 1968. This contrasts with a similar demonstration the day before, when a black teenager was killed by the police.